Israel’s victory was swift, crushing, and fateful. The Jewish state was now master of conquered territories from Suez to the Golan Heights and from Gaza to the Jordan Valley, and master of a Palestinian population that would soon number over 2 million.

Six years later, Egypt and Syria attempted to restore the military balance in the Yom Kippur War in October 1973. The sudden attacks were announced, on television to an Israeli public in total shock, by Defense Minister Moshe Dayan and Prime Minister Golda Meir. The turning point came with Israel’s counterattack, the crossing of the Suez Canal by Sharon’s forces and the encircling of the Egyptian Third Army.

Peace with Egypt and Jordan did not mean peace with the Palestinians and did not change the overall situation. Wars with the Arab neighboring states were replaced by escalating conflicts with Palestinian resistance organizations.

The First Lebanon War, in 1982, was launched by Israel against Yasser Arafat’s Palestine Liberation Organization, which had mounted attacks on Israel from southern Lebanon. The war aims, planned by the wily defense minister Sharon under the formal leadership of PM Menachem Begin, led to the uprooting of the PLO from Beirut and its relocation to Tunis, but little more than that. It also produced a fragile and short-lived alliance between Lebanese Christians and Israel. The siege of Beirut bears some resemblance to the present Gaza War: it was short and led nowhere.

The Second Lebanon War, in the summer of 2006, was even closer to the present situation. It started with Hezbollah kidnapping and killing Israeli soldiers on the northern border with Lebanon. The ensuing Israeli-Hezbollah conflict was difficult for the IDF: it faced a tough Shia opponent, fully armed and trained by Iran. It also led to growing Israeli disillusion with an aimless war. An end to the fighting was brokered by the UN in August 2006, but without any real resolution.